

CASE STUDY • LIVING DESIGN • 2024-2025

Airtable as Source of Truth

How a shared token infrastructure ended the translation war between
design and engineering

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No shared source of truth. Everyone was working alone.

DESIGN

Figma was restricted. The core team locked down their files — no direct access, no token contributions, no syncing.

ENGINEERING

iOS, Android, and Web each had their own token repos. GitHub was fragmented with no inheritance model.

COMMERCE

Commerce teams needed branding tokens, extended components, and multi-org support that core simply didn't offer.

Eroded trust between design and engineering.

- Teams were doing the same work twice — every team kept their own copy of the same tokens.
- Designers and engineers couldn't trust they were looking at the same thing. Decisions made in design were constantly re-litigated during implementation.
- Commerce teams had no clear place to go for answers, so they built in isolation — creating more inconsistency and more overhead.
- The cost wasn't just inefficiency. It was eroded trust.

One source everyone could actually use.



Designer-owned

Maintainable without engineering skills. Designers stay in control of their tokens.



Platform-agnostic

iOS, Android, and Web all pull from the same base at their own cadence.



Multi-brand

Support Walmart US, Sam's Club, Bodega, Cashi — without duplicating everything.



Scalable

Subsystem teams can extend without the core team becoming a bottleneck.

Airtable as Source of Truth.

× Figma

Core team restricted access. No versioning. Can't support cross-team inheritance.

× GitHub

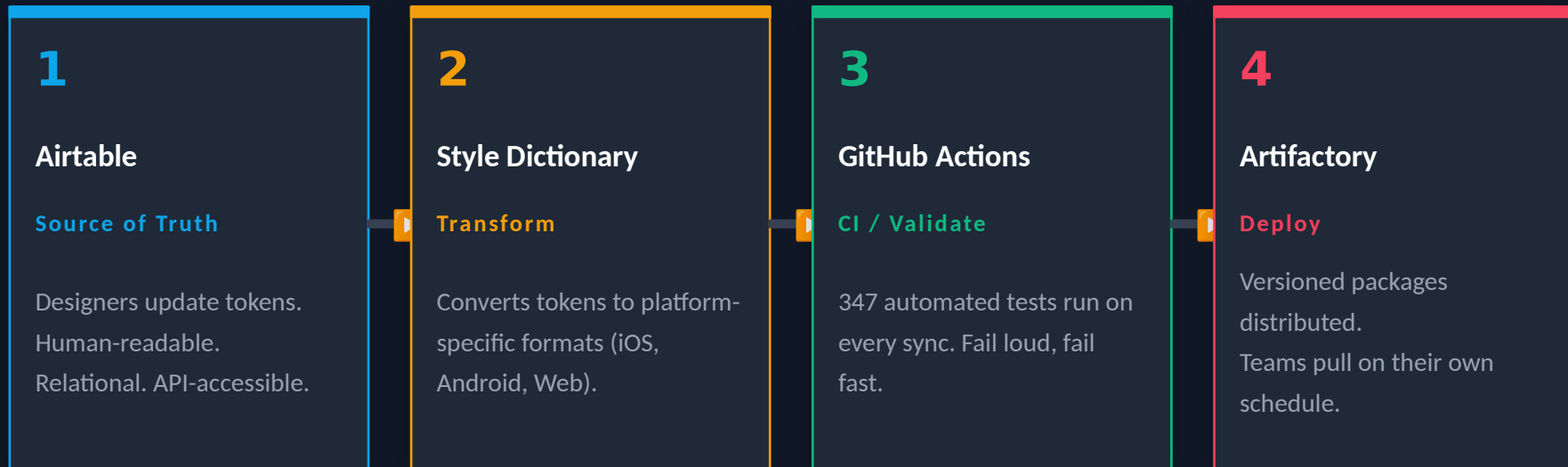
Requires engineering skills to edit safely. Design ownership breaks down when tokens live in JSON files.

Why Airtable

- Designers will actually use it correctly at scale — relational tables, not JSON files
- Engineers get a reliable API with structured, query-able token data
- Inheritance model enables multi-brand theming without duplication
- Human-readable enough for design, structured enough for automation

"Tool selection should follow team behavior — not the other way around."

Airtable → Style Dictionary → GitHub Actions → Artifactory



Designer updates a value → 10 minutes later it's live in production across all platforms

17 brands. One base.

Each layer only defines its overrides.

01 LD Base — Primitives

650+ tokens. Raw values. Shared by all brands.

100% shared

02 Semantic Layer

Alias tokens map intent → primitives (e.g. colorTextDefault → gray-900).

90% inherited

03 WCP Theme

Commerce-specific overrides only. Sam's Club, Walmart+ branch from here.

~20% override

04 Tenant Overrides

Brand-specific. Cashi, Bodega, Walmart Business. Only what's unique.

~10% override

When LD Base updates → all 17 downstream tenants receive the change automatically on the next sync

347 tests. If it breaks, the pipeline stops — not the product.

347

automated
tests per sync

Alias Integrity

Catches tokens referencing tokens that no longer exist — the silent failures that are nearly impossible to debug on native platforms without a full audit.

Hex-to-Token Purity

Verifies 100% of color values resolve through the alias chain. No hardcoded hex values allowed — they undermine the entire governance model.

Semantic Versioning

Breaking changes flag as major versions (2.0.0). New features as minor. Simple updates as patches. Teams control when to upgrade — no surprise breakages.

Design changes now reach production in 10 minutes. Zero coordination. Zero errors.

95%

faster deployment

2-3 days → 10 min

0%

error rate

347 automated tests

17

brand themes

all self-service

650

+

tokens managed

single source

THE BOTTOM LINE

**Designers work in Airtable.
Engineers consume versioned
tokens.
No coordination needed.**

What's next: Automated dynamic SVG theming for illustrations — the infrastructure is in place.